

The animal's lashing tail might have been used as a weapon to defend against predators.

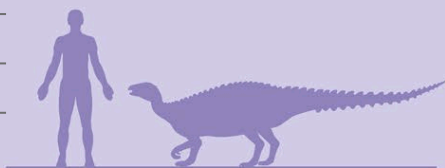
SPIKY SKIN

SCELIDOSAURUS

Scelidosaurus was one of the earliest armored dinosaurs. It was a relatively small herbivore with a body covered in bony spikes. Low-lying plants provided tasty meals for *Scelidosaurus*, which used its small teeth and simple up-and-down movements of its jaws to break up and chew tough leaves and twigs. Although *Scelidosaurus* is well known from some magnificently preserved specimens, paleontologists aren't sure which dinosaur family *Scelidosaurus* belongs to. Most agree it is one of a group of armored dinosaurs called thyreophorans, which includes the more famous stegosaurs and ankylosaurs.

AT A GLANCE

- **LENGTH** 13 ft (4 m)
- **DIET** Herbivore
- **LIVED** 199-190 MYA
- **HABITAT** Forests



Scelidosaurus's toes were tipped with blunt claws.